‘Nehru’s contests were always over ideas, never any personal interests of his own,’ argued Crocker (and other biographers), ‘though he waged them without quarter and provoked a good deal of personal enmity.’[12] This is, of course, not strictly true, because there was often more than a tinge of instrumental rationality about many of these contests – especially when Nehru contested the views of his peers. The ways he waged these conflicts, the tools that he deployed and the reasoning he provided marked each such contest as a part of Nehru’s manoeuvring for short-term gain and acquiring and consolidating political power; they expressed his tactical and strategic side as much as they did the visionary and the ideational. Engaging in these contests, Nehru and his contemporaries delineated their ideological positions, offered competing visions and configurations for the future, and staked out the political terrain – with consequences that reverberate to this day.

This book shines a spotlight on four such consequential debates that Nehru engaged in: with the poet-philosopher Muhammad Iqbal, with the Muslim League leader and the founder of Pakistan Mohammad Ali Jinnah, with his colleague and deputy Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and with his first counterfoil in Parliament, Syama Prasad Mookerjee. With Jinnah, Nehru exchanged rancorous letters on Hindu-Muslim relations and the demands of the Muslim League. With Iqbal, he contested the meaning of Muslim solidarity, and the role of religion and religious orthodoxy in public life. Patel and Nehru crossed swords over India’s policy towards China and Tibet. And with Mookerjee, Nehru clashed in Parliament over civil liberties and the First Amendment to the Constitution. All four debates represent critical junctures in South Asian history, moments that decided which way the pendulum of events would swing. Each debate is thus a crucial part of the events that followed: unbeknownst to them, for example, Nehru and Jinnah’s arguments were the opening act of Partition, in the same way as Patel’s confrontation with Nehru contained the seeds of 1962.

‘Nehru’s political career was rooted in a vision of a new India,’ stated Judith Brown, one of Nehru’s biographers, ‘… [and] appreciating the origins and power of this vision is essential for an understanding of the